



Dinesh Kanabar (centre), CEO of Dhruva Advisors, with colleagues

PHOTO BY MILIND SHELTE

vice firms, so they knew the inner workings of their rivals. The four who partnered with him to set up Dhruva were all in KPMG, having worked with at least one other of the Big Four.

The decision to be only in tax has paid off. Today, Dhruva handles tax problems of the biggest names across sectors—Reliance Industries, Adani, JSW, Warburg Pincus, Blackstone and Culver Max Entertainment, among others. Kanabar says, “The more complex the transaction or litigation or a restructuring, the higher the chance of Dhruva being there.”

In the last decade, Dhruva has positioned itself as a firm that can handle complex matters. Dhruva claims it takes “full ownership” of its advice, and does not weave in “caveats” to protect itself if things go south.

MAKING IT WORK

But despite the clarity of the vision of “offering a solution”, Dhruva did not jump into it. It spent time on understanding the challenge. Kanabar says they prefer to handle complex problems of big clients and charge a premium for their solutions. Not for them the volume game of handling routine problems of many small clients. “There is a trust factor that we can deliver an out-of-the-box solution that others cannot,” says Kanabar quite plainly.

Success came relatively quickly. Dhruva soon outgrew the 4,000 sq. ft office, where it began life. It moved to 15,000 sq. ft digs in central Mumbai as work came in faster than Kanabar had anticipated. He admits that the firm “is perhaps expensive

but is worth the buck spent since it has a single-minded focus on the client’s problem.”

STAFFING NUMBERS

Take the PVR-Inox merger announced in March 2022. The lockdowns triggered by the 2020 Covid-19 pandemic and the social distancing that followed had laid low the two listed multiplex players.

Their competition was history; the future lay in a merger. The combined entity would need to go through several clearances, always with the fear of being struck down as going against the laws against monopolies.

Kanabar says this was a unique transaction where two successful entrepreneurs (Ajay Bijli of PVR and Siddharth Jain of Inox) were coming